

OSINT Intelligence Report: 1755 Nova Scotia Displacements

Geopolitical Assessment, Operational Deconstruction of *Le Grand Dérangement*, Asymmetric Colonial Warfare, and Contemporary International Legal Frameworks

CLASSIFICATION: Open Source Intelligence (OSINT)

INVESTIGATION REF: HTR-1755-NS-EXPULSION

SUBJECT ENTITIES: British Colonial Admin, Acadian Population, Wabanaki Confederacy

TARGET DOMAIN: Acadie / Mi'kma'ki / Maritime Frontier (1710–1764)

METHODOLOGICAL MATRIX: NATO / UN Human Rights Commission Standards

LEGAL CORPUS: 1948 UNGC (Art. II), 1998 Rome Statute (Art. 7), Customary IHL

1. Executive Summary & Strategic Context

This intelligence assessment delivers a systematic reconstruction of the state-sponsored mass deportation, land dispossession, and demographic dispersal campaign executed by the British Crown against the Acadian inhabitants of Nova Scotia (historic *Acadie*) between 1755 and 1764, known historiographically as *Le Grand Dérangement* (The Great Upheaval). Concurrently, this assessment evaluates the synchronized counter-insurgency and demographic clearance operations directed against the sovereign nations of the Wabanaki Confederacy—principally the Mi'kmaq and Wolastoqiyik (Maliseet)—whose unceded ancestral domain (*Mi'kma'ki*) formed the contested theater.

Utilizing colonial council minutes, naval logistics ledgers, field directives, and contemporary international legal standards, this report deconstructs the operational doctrine conceived by Nova Scotia Lieutenant Governor (later Governor) Charles Lawrence, Massachusetts Governor William Shirley, and the Nova Scotia Council. Operating in the prelude to the Seven Years' War (1756–1763), British provincial authorities executed an asymmetric infrastructure-denial and demographic-clearing operation designed to eliminate potential French-aligned populations along the North American eastern seaboard.

The campaign resulted in the forced deportation of approximately 11,500 to 14,100 Acadians (over 75% of their total demographic base), the systemic destruction of over 3,000 agrarian domiciles, barns, and mills, the breaching of centuries-old *aboiteau* dike systems, the confiscation of tens of thousands of livestock, and an aggregate mortality rate estimated between 30% and 45% (4,000 to 6,000+ fatalities) resulting from shipboard epidemics, malnutrition, exposure, marine disasters, and extrajudicial military actions.

2. Scope, Target Profile & Stakeholder Matrix

The operational theater spans the Maritime provinces (Nova Scotia, New Brunswick, Prince Edward Island), eastern Maine, the Gulf of St. Lawrence, and naval dispersal routes extending across the American Atlantic seaboard, the Caribbean, the British Isles, and mainland France.

Actor / Entity	Strategic Orientation	Operational Role & Capabilities	Primary Objectives
Acadian Population (<i>Les Acadiens</i>)	Nominal British subjects claiming "Neutral French" (<i>Français neutres</i>) status under conditional oaths (1729–1730).	Agrarian mastery of tidal marshlands via complex <i>aboiteau</i> dike engineering; self-sustaining economy; close kinship/trade ties with Mi'kmaq; absence of standing military forces.	Preservation of Catholic faith, retention of ancestral landholdings, exemption from bearing arms against France or Indigenous allies, and political neutrality.
Wabanaki Confederacy (Mi'kmaq, Wolastoqiyik)	Sovereign Indigenous nations; military-spiritual alliance with French Crown via Catholic missions; custodians of <i>Mi'kma'ki</i> .	Irregular asymmetric warfare; maritime raiding in littoral zones; guerrilla ambushes; environmental intelligence; defensive alliance with Acadian resistance.	Halting British settlement expansion; enforcing 1725/1726 Peace and Friendship Treaty boundaries; expelling British military garrisons.
British Colonial Administration	Imperial colonial executive (Gov. Charles Lawrence, Gov. William Shirley, Lt. Col. Robert Monckton, Lt. Col. John Winslow).	Royal Navy fleet logistics (Adm. Edward Boscawen); Massachusetts provincial regular and militia regiments; regional forts (Fort Edward, Fort Cumberland, Fort Anne).	Total pacification and anglicization of Nova Scotia frontier; annexation of fertile marshlands for Protestant Planters; eliminating borderland security risks.
French Imperial Command (Louisbourg & Quebec)	Imperial rival (Gov. Gen. Vaudreuil, Drucour at Louisbourg, Charles Deschamps de Boishébert).	Fortress Louisbourg naval/garrison bastion; Fort Beauséjour and Fort Gaspereaux; supply lines to irregular Acadian-Indigenous resistance fighters.	Containment of British expansion; weaponization of Acadian border refugees; maintaining strategic supply corridors between Quebec and the Atlantic.

3. Historical Timeline & Key Operations (1710–1764)

Date / Period	Operational Milestone	Tactical Execution & Strategic Impact	Severity Status
October 1710	Capture of Port-Royal	British forces under Francis Nicholson capture Port-Royal (renamed Annapolis Royal). British crown sovereignty asserted over peninsular Nova Scotia.	TRANSITION
April 1713	Treaty of Utrecht (Art. XIV)	France cedes peninsular Acadie to Britain. Acadians granted conditional liberty to retain lands or emigrate within one year; departure is never facilitated.	LEGAL AMBIGUITY
1729–1730	Conditional Oath of Allegiance	Acadians subscribe to conditional oaths under Gov. Richard Philipps containing verbal/written exemptions from bearing arms, establishing "Neutral French" status.	DE FACTO NEUTRALITY
June 1749	Founding of Halifax Base	Gov. Edward Cornwallis arrives with 2,500 settlers to establish fortified base at Chebucto (Halifax) to counter Louisbourg, disregarding Mi'kmaw territorial sovereignty.	ESCALATION
October 1749	Cornwallis Scalp Proclamation	Nova Scotia Council authorizes bounty of 10 guineas (later 50) for every Mi'kmaw captured or killed, formalizing total asymmetric warfare against Indigenous populations.	STATE VIOLENCE
1749–1755	Father Le Loutre's	Abbé Le Loutre orchestrates	HYBRID CONFLICT

	War	guerrilla resistance and encourages Acadians to migrate across Missaguash River to French-controlled Chignecto and Île Saint-Jean.	
June 16, 1755	Fall of Fort Beauséjour	Lt. Col. Robert Monckton captures Fort Beauséjour; finds ~300 armed Acadians inside (who claimed forced impressment). Lawrence utilizes this as justification for wholesale removal.	CAUSAL PRETEXT
July 28, 1755	Expulsion Decree Signed	Gov. Charles Lawrence, Admiral Boscawen, and the Council summarily order complete deportation and asset seizure of all Acadians refusing an unconditional oath.	OPERATIONAL MANDATE
Aug–Nov 1755	Roundups at Grand-Pré & Mines	Lt. Col. John Winslow and Capt. Alexander Murray assemble Acadian men in parish churches, arrest them as prisoners of war, and begin forced transport loading and village burning.	MASS DEPORTATION
September 1755	Battle of Petitcodiac	Acadian resistance under Joseph Broussard dit Beausoleil and Mi'kmaw allies ambushes British forces under Major Frye, killing 23 British soldiers and temporarily halting village burnings.	ARMED RESISTANCE
1758	Fall of Louisbourg & Île Saint-Jean	Second wave: British forces under Col. Andrew Rollo round up 3,100+ Acadians on Île Saint-Jean; marine disasters claim ~1,000 lives on transport ships	MARINE ATTRITION

		Duke William, Violet, and Ruby.	
1758–1762	Gulf of St. Lawrence Raids	Scorched-earth punitive expeditions destroy remaining Acadian settlements along Saint John River, Miramichi, Gaspé, and Baie des Chaleurs.	SCORCHED EARTH
1763–1764	Treaty of Paris & Resettlement	France cedes New France; deportation directives cease. Acadians permitted conditional return in small, dispersed groups, barred from reclaiming original marshlands.	DISPERSED RETURN

4. Threat Assessment, Military Doctrine & Mechanization

4.1 Logistical Mobilization & Fleet Chartering

The deportation relied on centralized administrative planning executed via Boston merchant contractors (Thomas Hancock and Charles Apthorp). More than 40 commercial vessels were chartered and refitted into prison transports. Transport regulations specifying 2 tons per passenger were disregarded, with field allocations reduced to 0.5 to 0.75 tons per passenger, creating severe sub-deck overcrowding, oxygen deprivation, and accelerated epidemic spread (typhus, smallpox, dysentery).

4.2 Scorched-Earth Doctrine & Infrastructure Denial

To eliminate survival capabilities and prevent deported populations or forest refugees from returning, British field commanders executed comprehensive infrastructure denial:

Lt. Col. John Winslow's Declaration (Grand-Pré, September 5, 1755):

"Your Lands & Tennements, Cattle of all Kinds and Live Stock of all Sortes are Forfeited to the Crown with all other your Effects Saving your money and Household Goods, and you Yourselfs to be Removed out of this his Province... I Shall Deliver to you your orders Each Family to prepare themselves to put on Board the Vessells."

- **Structural Incineration:** Over 255 houses, 276 barns, 11 mills, and 1 church were burned in Grand-Pré alone. Across the province, over 3,000 domestic structures were destroyed.
- **Livestock Seizure:** In the Mines basin alone, over 1,260 oxen, 1,550 dairy cows, 5,000 sheep, and 490 hogs were confiscated or culled.
- **Aboiteau Sabotage:** Crucial agricultural dikes holding back high Bay of Fundy tides were breached or left to decay, allowing saltwater inundation to ruin alluvial soil chemistry for years.

4.3 Destination Profiles & Transatlantic Dispersal

Destination Node	Deportees (Est.)	Reception Conditions & Administrative Actions	Estimated Mortality
Massachusetts Bay	2,000	Dispersed across inland towns; minors bound out as indentured servants; travel restricted.	15% – 20%
Connecticut	700	Distributed to municipal selectmen; agricultural labor; postwar migration to Quebec.	10% – 15%
New York & Pennsylvania	1,200	Quarantined on Province Island (Philadelphia) due to smallpox; hundreds died in port holds.	25% – 35%
Maryland	1,000	Relatively humane reception due to Catholic presence; established "French Town" in Baltimore.	10% – 12%
Virginia	1,150	Debarkation refused by Gov. Dinwiddie; ships rerouted to internment camps in England.	30% – 40%
The Carolinas & Georgia	1,500	Indentured field labor; multiple groups attempted return voyages north in coastal boats.	20% – 30%
Île Saint-Jean to France (1758)	3,100	Transatlantic winter sinkings of <i>Duke William</i> , <i>Violet</i> , and <i>Ruby</i> ; survivors landed in Saint-Malo/Brest.	40% – 50%

5. Asymmetric Resistance & Indigenous Sovereignty

The pre-1755 Acadian communities maintained deep familial, spiritual, and economic interconnections with the Mi'kmaq Nation. Following the onset of deportations, armed partisan resistance developed along the river valleys:

- **Joseph Broussard dit Beausoleil:** Commanded irregular partisan detachments along the Petitcodiac River, engaging British detachments and capturing naval supply vessels in the Bay of Fundy.
- **Charles Deschamps de Boishébert:** French regular officer coordinating refugee assistance at Camp d'Espérance (Miramichi), though winter supply failures led to over 1,000 civilian famine deaths.
- **Mi'kmaw Naval Operations:** Sovereign Mi'kmaw seafarers captured over 60 British commercial and military vessels between 1715 and 1760, contesting British maritime dominance in regional straits.

Governor Edward Cornwallis Scalp Proclamation (October 2, 1749):

"Do hereby Authorize and give full power to all Officers, Civil and Military, and all His Majesty's Liege Subjects, to annoy, distress, take or destroy the Salvages commonly called Micmacks, wherever they are found... and we Promise a reward of Ten Guineas for every Indian Micmack taken or killed, producing the Scalp of every Indian Micmack."

6. Quantitative Demographic & Mortality Matrix

Pre-Expulsion Demographic Baseline (1755): Approx. 14,000 – 15,000 Acadians across peninsular Nova Scotia, Chignecto, Île Saint-Jean, and Île Royale.

Demographic Segment	Estimated Count	Primary Mechanism & Documentation Sources
Total Acadians Deported (1755–1764)	11,500 – 12,500	Colonial embarkation manifests and provincial receipt ledgers.
Refugees Fleeing to Forest Encampments	2,500 – 3,500	Escape routes to Quebec, Miramichi, Restigouche, and Saint John River.
Direct Marine Attrition (Sinkings)	1,000 – 1,200	Documented loss of <i>Duke William</i> (~360), <i>Violet</i> (~280), <i>Ruby</i> (~210).
Shipboard Disease Mortality	1,500 – 2,200	Typhus, smallpox